certainly at that point in time be unable to handle a new disease and a high caseload, and we would lose lakhs of lives. The migrants would have to stay in the cities. At least until we were able to build some capacities in terms of beds and testing kits, and supply essential medicines and ventilators to the rural and semi-urban hospitals. The last time the Indian government was needed to rise to a challenge of this magnitude was perhaps during the time of Partition in 1947, when it had to mobilize all of its bureaucracy and security forces to rehabilitate people arriving in the country while ensuring that the security situation remained under control.

When the suggestion to announce lockdown within the next couple of days was made, the prime minister put his foot down. He opined that with no notice at all, we cannot ask 1.3+ billion people to stay where they are. Parliament was in session, Members of Parliament would need to return to their home constituencies to assist the people in the difficult times that lay ahead of us. Citizens may have other kinds of emergencies as well like aged parents living alone to be moved, or children in boarding schools to be brought home. Some sort of preview of the upcoming weeks to prepare the citizens must be offered. The prime minister has made it a practice to involve people in every major initiative that he undertakes in the spirit of *jan bhagidari* (people's participation/people partnership). The steps India had to take in the days ahead would not be possible without that spirit. He had been keenly observing the trends in various parts of the country and knew that high-handedness would not work. As a man who has spent at least a night in almost every district of India, he has a tremendous grip on the psyche of the Indian people. With the richness of this experience, he fully understood the challenges associated with the diversity, the geography and complexity of India. As a result, he thought of a day-long, self-imposed curfew—a junta curfew, just a couple of days before completely locking down. Even though the curfew would be self-imposed, it would be crucial for every single Indian to get the prime minister's message. The question arose: how would we get important messages across to every single Indian in such a limited time frame? This question would occupy the prime minister's mind frequently over the course of the next few months. As someone who frequently referred to history pages for reference and inspiration, the prime minister was well aware that for Mahatma Gandhi too, it was challenging to get the entire nation behind the freedom struggle, especially the Northeast. In fact, at the time before Independence, the